

**To what extent were Mao Zedong's Tactical Leadership Abilities Responsible
for his rise to power in China from 1935 to 1949?**

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IDENTIFICATION AND EVALUATION OF SOURCES:

The focus of this investigation will be “To what extent did Mao Zedong’s tactical leadership abilities lead to his rise in power from 1935 to 1949?” The first source is a journal article published in 1986 by Benjamin Yang and is relevant to the investigation because it focuses on the Zunyi conference, a significant event during Mao’s rise to power. The second source is another journal article, published in 1996, by Tu Wei-ming. It is relevant to the investigation because an Intentionalist perspective is analyzed with respect specifically to Mao’s “ingenuity”.

Source One: *The Zunyi Conference as One Step in Mao’s Rise to Power: A Survey of Historical Studies of the Chinese Communist Party*, Thomas Kampen, From The China Quarterly June 1986 by Benjamin Yang.

The origin’s value of this source is that it originates from Thomas Kampen, a political scientist and academic who cited and analyzed many credible primary sources, including direct quotes. It is valuable because Kampen has written multiple articles on China and therefore has an enriched and reliable perspective on Mao. The value of the purpose is that it was written to critically examine the Zunyi Conference as a specific event in Mao’s rise to power, providing direct insight for my exploration which will be further investigated to make an educated conclusion on the causes of Mao’s rise to power.

A limitation of the origin is that this article is a secondary source, meaning it doesn’t contain firsthand information from the events and likely missed key information. Therefore, it must be cross referenced with primary sources to ensure the information is accurate. A limitation of the content is that the article solely focuses on the Zunyi conference. Although this is one

perspective to be analyzed, it is not the sole reason for Mao's rise to power because other factors such as his ability to lead masses are also significant. This is limiting for the investigation as all possible events should be considered when analyzing the history of Mao's rise to power as a whole.

Source Two: *Destructive Will and Ideological Holocaust: Maoism as a Source of Social Suffering in China*, 1996 by Tu Wei-ming.

The origin of this book is valuable as it is written by Tu Wei-ming, a Chinese-born American historian and philosopher. Tu is a credible historian who studied altruism under the ideas of Confucius. Since Confucianism focuses on one's inner integrity, Tu would have an objective and unbiased view on Mao's rule in China, proving to be of value to my exploration. The value of the content is that Mao's life before gaining power is discussed which provides better insight to the investigation as it touches upon many factors involved in his rise to power. Facts such as his role in the Long March right before the Zunyi conference are given, and are valuable to the investigation because it allows readers to better understand Mao and thus come to a conclusion in terms of what led to his rise in power.

A limitation of the origin is that Tu spent a majority of his life in America. This would limit his access to primary sources because the majority of sources regarding Mao would only be available in China due to censorship. Thus, his book may lack important information surrounding Mao's rise to power that would only be known in China. The purpose of this book is also limiting because the author's intention is to portray Mao in a negative light to change people's perspectives on Maoism. This is seen in the title, where Maoism is described by "suffering". Although the facts in the book are unbiased because they have strong sources

backing them, some events have extra emphasis placed on them, making them seem more important than they actually were in Mao's route to power.

INVESTIGATION

Mao officially became the leader of the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) in 1935 and established the People's Republic of China in 1949. The question of how he rose to power has long been debated and still remains a question to this day. In the Long March of 1934, a successful military retreat led by Mao, the Zunyi conference was held¹. This was a conference to discuss critical issues within the CCP, and acted as the first step in gaining power which would eventually allow him to rule China for many years.² The historiography of this topic is characterized by the debate between Accidentalists and Intentionalists. Accidentalists primarily believe that Mao's coming to power was due to luck and events such as the decline of the nationalist Kuomintang Party (KMT) under Chiang Kai Shek³, whereas Intentionalists say that Mao's military genius and strategies were what allowed him to be "the most revered and ecstatically worshiped man of the century", as Lucian Pye states⁴. Both of these views must be further explored in order to discern the extent to which Mao's leadership abilities were responsible for his rise to power in China.

¹ Kampen, Thomas. (1989). The Zunyi Conference and Further Steps in Mao's Rise to Power. *The China Quarterly*, 117, 118–134.
https://www.jstor.org/stable/654714?searchText=zunyi&searchUri=%2Faction%2FdoBasicSearch%3FQuery%3Dzunyi%26so%3Drel&ab_segments=0%2Fbasic_search_gsv2_SYC-7149%2Ftest&refreqid=fastly-default%3A0d2cd7d688335776adadd446cfa5ebfb

² Kampen, 117.

³ Meisner, Maurice J. (1986) *Mao's China: A History of the People's Republic*. New York: Free Press, London: Collier Macmillan.

⁴ Pye, Lucian W. (1976). Mao Tse-Tung's Leadership Style. *Political Science Quarterly* 91, no. 2: 219–35.
<https://doi.org/10.2307/2148410>.

Accidentalists historians primarily believe that the decline of the Nationalist government under Chiang Kai Shek allowed Mao's CCP to prosper, and eventually for him to lead China. They believe the decline of the KMT after the first world war was what allowed Mao to be widely accepted. The KMT, led by Chiang, prioritized destroying the CCP and communists over preventing an invasion from Japan at this time. This led to unrest between the Chinese civilians, many of whom were living under the slogan "Chinese do not fight Chinese"⁵. It also resulted in a lack of national unity and support for Chiang's campaigns.⁶ Maurice Meisner states that during the Japanese invasion of Manchuria (Northern China), "The retreat of Kuomintang military forces to the west in the face of invading Japanese armies and the current collapse of the Nationalist governmental authority in much of China allowed the communists to...expand their military and political influence.", examining the fact that if these chances were not presented to Mao, there would be no way he could become ruler.⁷

Meisner states that it was the Japanese invasion of Manchuria which "undermined the foundations of the KMT regime" because they stripped the KMT of "financial and political support".⁸ Manchuria was abundant in raw resources, which the Japanese thought were critical for their self-sufficiency. The CCP and KMT's inability to cooperate played a large factor in the CCP's victory. Additionally, Thomas Kampen states the Zunyi Conference as a critical point.⁹ Kampen states that the CCP had "just happened" to make Mao the leader of the China Communist Party at the Zunyi conference.¹⁰ Many "accidental occurrences" such as Mao's position as a "spokesperson for the opposition" during the Fifth Anti-Encirclement Campaign (a

⁵ Todd, A. (2015). *History for the IB diploma. paper 1, the move to Global War*. Cambridge University Press, 48-49.

⁶ Todd, 50.

⁷ Meisner, Maurice J. (1986) *Mao's China: A History of the People's Republic*. New York: Free Press, London: Collier Macmillan.

⁸ Meisner, Maurice J. (1986) *Mao's China: A History of the People's Republic*. New York: Free Press, London: Collier Macmillan.

⁹ Kampen, 135-171.

¹⁰ Kampen, 135-171.

battle between the KMT and CCP during the Chinese Civil War) benefited him as the campaign was a massive failure for the CCP¹¹. His position also gave him an advantage at the time because he was “no longer in charge of practical matters and had become merely a figurehead”,¹² suggesting that he would not have to take responsibility for this failure and “should be regarded as his good fortune, en route to seizing supreme Party power.”¹³ The decline in leadership of the party under Chiang Kai Shek allowed Mao to become leader of the CCP, and gain popularity.

However, this perspective of Mao’s rise to power through “coincidental events” is viewed by Intentionalists as merely superficial. Intentionalists hold that Mao’s power was purely a result of his ability to inspire masses, interpreting the decisions at the Zunyi conference as being made because Mao had proven himself. Benjamin Schwartz states that “Mao’s leadership was established by his ingenuity as a military strategist, fearlessness as a revolutionary, vision as a theoretician, persuasion as an ideologist, rapport with the peasant community, and charisma”, suggesting that Mao was so well-rounded that it was without doubt he would gain utmost power.¹⁴

Oxford Dictionaries defines “ingenious” as being “suitable for a particular purpose and as a result of clever ideas”, which, according to some, is a good match with Mao’s personality.¹⁵ Edgar Snow states that Mao had revelations about power from an early age, emphasizing his superiority to his classmates.¹⁶ Mao agreed with left-wing views and tended towards the socialist ideology, likely influenced by his teacher who was a radical. From an early age, he read many books, and began to understand politics like no one had before. Even in his household, his father

¹¹ Kampen, 252.

¹² Kampen, 252.

¹³ Kampen, 253.

¹⁴ Wei-ming, Tu. (1996). *Destructive Will and Ideological Holocaust: Maoism as a Source of Social Suffering in China*. Daedalus, 125(1), 149–179.

¹⁵ Definition of “Ingenious” from *Advanced Oxford Dictionary*. University of Oxford Press, Oxford.

¹⁶ Snow, Edgar. (1961) “The Classic account of the birth of Chinese Communism” *Red Star over China*. Grove Press.

was against the ideologies of Mao and his mother, which depicts two political parties in one household. Mao was able to make a conclusion “when I defended my rights by open rebellion, my father relented.”,¹⁷ examining the fact that his strategies and brilliance truly developed far before adulthood and was the main contributor to his rise in power. This suggests his brilliance existed far before he even joined the CCP. It is therefore evident that due to Mao’s personality, he wouldn’t have ruled China. Finally, Lucian W. Pye looks into Mao’s leadership genius, stating that “the secret of his greatness lies elsewhere - in his extraordinary ability to understand, evoke, and direct human emotions....” This implies that Mao’s capabilities extended far beyond military strategies, further supporting the intentionalist perspective that Mao’s personality and intentions were what allowed him to be accepted by the wide Chinese population.¹⁸

With sufficient evidence to support both of these perspectives, a combination of multiple historiographies provides the best explanation for Mao’s rise to power. Although historians such as Lucien Pye state the ingenuity of Chairman Mao, they also recognize that there were multiple other factors at play in determining Mao’s true genius, such as his timing in bringing the CCP to power during a time where it was extremely weak and frequently purged by the Nationalists under Chiang’s Extermination Campaigns.¹⁹ Pye suggests that “few have not been touched by his [Mao’s] existence, whether in admiration or hatred, respect or scorn”, recognizing that Mao’s power covered many aspects to the extent that almost everyone formed opinions about him.²⁰ The first step to his rise to power started in his early childhood. From an Accidentalist perspective, if Mao hadn’t been born into a divided family²¹, been influenced by radical teachers,

¹⁷ Snow, Edgar. (1961) “The Classic account of the birth of Chinese Communism” *Red Star over China*. Grove Press.

¹⁸ Pye, Lucian W. (1976). Mao Tse-Tung’s Leadership Style. *Political Science Quarterly* 91, no. 2: 219–35. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2148410>.

¹⁹ Todd, 50.

²⁰ Pye, 219–35.

²¹ Snow, Edgar. (1961) “The Classic account of the birth of Chinese Communism” *Red Star over China*. Grove Press.

run away from home many times²², and if the Zunyi conference hadn't appointed him leader of the CCP, he wouldn't have had so much power²³. From looking at both perspectives, their interconnectedness is evident. Mao's brilliance gave him opportunities to rise to power, but he wouldn't have brilliance without opportunities. However, what must also be considered is that Mao's seemingly unlimited dictatorial power might not have been due to his success as a person, but was rooted in the authoritarian communist ideology itself.²⁴ There is evidence to suggest that both the Intentionalist and Accidentalist approaches prove justifiable explanations for Mao's long route to power, as it would have been impossible without any brilliance.²⁵ This is surely enough to explain that a synthesis of the two perspectives provides evidence in how Mao truly rose to power during a period of political failure in China. Thus, a single historiography is not sufficient to explain the powerful dictatorship by Mao in the years of his rule.

REFLECTION

This exploration has prompted me to consider the many challenges facing historians, especially the limitations of interpreting sources. Through research, I came to realize the difficulty of gaining accurate historical knowledge based on inferences. Although secondary sources provide lots of information and are easier to understand than primary sources, biases and misinformation are inherently present. Even if the source is primary, bias is often still incorporated because such sources are often more difficult to interpret. For example, when looking into Mao's childhood, many sources provided a falsely positive portrayal of Mao. These

²² Snow, Edgar. (1961) "The Classic account of the birth of Chinese Communism" *Red Star over China*. Grove Press.

²³ Kampen, 235-271.

²⁴ Wei-ming, Tu. (1996). *Destructive Will and Ideological Holocaust: Maoism as a Source of Social Suffering in China*. Daedalus, 125(1), 149–179.

²⁵ Schwartz, Benjamin. On the "Originality" of Mao Tse-Tung. (1955). 67.

primary sources have been altered by the Chinese government to use as propaganda portraying Mao as a hero, and thus would be extremely biased.

To overcome this limitation, historians must rely on cross referencing to ensure that information is as objective as possible. This is both a benefit and a challenge for historians. It's beneficial because the use of multiple sources will confirm the facts shared between them, but also challenging because fact selection becomes a problem. Interpreting history has a heavy reliance on the historian to decide what is correct versus what is not because there is no way to truly know the authenticity of a source. Certain facts must appeal to individuals more than others, and the challenge becomes choosing the "right" facts that put together a comprehensive picture of history. I was aware of this in my investigation and chose facts from secondary sources based on the strength of the sources backing it. This, combined with the primary sources itself, provided me with the most accurate picture of Mao's upbringing and the causes of his rise to power.

Moreover, I found that looking at alternate perspectives is also challenging for historians. Information is broad and often fits multiple perspectives. Mao's childhood teacher was a radical - but was it Mao's destiny to become a dictator, or was it an accident that he happened to acquire political views early on? Since it is difficult to differentiate such interconnected views, I had to investigate them together to come to the conclusion that neither argument could be explained alone. Other times, the lack of information makes it extremely difficult to consider multiple perspectives. Since this investigation centers around China, where heavy censorship laws exist, there are many perspectives on historical events that are inaccessible. This investigation allowed me to explore and apply many methods of historical research, and to overcome the challenges they entail.

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